

project.org

STUDENT HANDOUT

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Fact-Checker Training

Grades 3–4

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Optical illusions exploit weaknesses in how our brains process visual information. Our brains take shortcuts (called "heuristics") to quickly make sense of the world—but these shortcuts can be manipulated. Throughout history, people have exploited these weaknesses: spirit photographers in the 1860s, propaganda during wars, and now deepfakes and viral misinformation.

01 PART 1

Why Do People Believe Fake Things?

Research shows people are more likely to believe misinformation when it:

- Confirms what they already believe (**confirmation bias**)
- Triggers strong emotions (fear, anger, excitement)
- Comes from people they trust (friends, family, celebrities)
- Looks professional (good design, official-sounding language)
- Is repeated often (the more you see something, the more "true" it feels)

Think about it: How do optical illusions use some of these same tricks?

02 PART 2

Create Your Own Fact-Checker Guide

Design a guide you could give to younger students or family members. Include:

- A catchy title
- 3–5 rules in your own words (not just copied from class)
- At least one example of each rule in action
- Illustrations or diagrams if helpful

Use the back of page 2 or a separate sheet. Be creative!

PART 3

03 Analysis Challenge

Think of a piece of misinformation you've heard about (or ask an adult about one). Analyze it:

What was the false claim?

Why do you think people believed it? (Which psychological factors from above?)

How could you have fact-checked it?

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Mini Museum Deep Dive. When you visit (or explore online at minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving/illusions), examine the stereoscope carefully. It works by showing each eye a slightly different image—your brain combines them into 3D. This exploits *binocular vision*.

Spirit photographers exploited *double exposure*. Deepfakes exploit *AI pattern recognition*. Different eras, same principle: find the weakness, exploit it.

PART 4

04 Compare the Tricks

Fill in the chart comparing different types of visual deception:

TYPE OF TRICK	HOW IT WORKS	HOW TO SPOT IT
Optical Illusion		
Spirit Photography		
Deepfakes Today		

PART 5

05 Think Deeper

What do all of these tricks have in common?

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Research Project: With your family, research one historical example of visual deception (spirit photography, wartime propaganda, early Photoshop hoaxes). Create a mini-presentation: What was the trick? Why did people believe it? How was it eventually exposed?